我的中文名字

一个外国学生找新名字

My Chinese Name

A foreign student looks for a new name

Text and translation by Claude (Anthropic)

Footnotes mark names and words above HSK 2 (HSK 3.0 lists: github.com/ivankra/hsk30, MIT).

1 马克[†]在中国的一个大学学习汉语。来中国以前，他在网上找了一个中文名字。这个名字是一个网站给他的，叫“马路”。因为“马[‡]”的读音跟他的英文名字有点儿像，所以他很喜欢这个名字。

大家都笑了

2 第一天上课，王[§]老师说：“请大家说一说自己的中文名字。”马克站起来说：“大家好，我姓马，叫马路。”他说完，同学们都笑了，王老师也笑了。马克不知道大家为什么笑。

3 下课以后，马克去一个小饭馆吃饭。饭馆的主人是一个很热情的老人，他问：“你叫什么名字？”马克说：“我叫马路。”老人笑着看了看门外，说：“马路？外边那条也叫马路！”

† 马克 *Mǎkè* Mark, a foreign student
‡ 马 *Mǎ* Ma (a surname)
§ 王 *Wáng* Wang (the teacher's surname)

Mark is studying Chinese at a university in China. Before he came to China, he found himself a Chinese name online. It was a website that gave him the name: Ma Lu. Because "Ma" sounded a bit like his English name, he liked it very much. 1

Everyone Laughed

On the first day of class, Teacher Wang said, "Please tell us your Chinese names." Mark stood up and said, "Hello, everyone. My surname is Ma, and my name is Ma Lu." When he finished, all his classmates laughed, and so did Teacher Wang. Mark had no idea why everyone was laughing. 2

After class, Mark went to a little restaurant to eat. The owner, a very friendly old man, asked, "What's your name?" "My name is Ma Lu," said Mark. The old man smiled, glanced out of the door and said, "Ma Lu? That thing outside is called a ma lu too!" 3

3 马克[†]还是不明白。他想：我的名字为什么跟外边的路一样？

名字的意思

4 第二天，马克去办公室问王[‡]老师：“老师，大家为什么都笑我的名字？”王老师说：“你看外边的路，汽车在上边走，人也在上边走。这样的路，中文叫‘马路’。”马克听了，脸都红了：“原来我的名字是‘路’！因为我叫‘马路’，所以大家都笑了！”王老师说：“对。可是大家不是笑你，是觉得这个名字很有意思。”

5 然后，王老师告诉马克中国人的名字是怎么来的。中国人的名字，姓在前边，名在后边。比如“王小明[§]”，他姓王，叫小明[¶]。姓常常是一个字；名有的是一个字，有的是两个字。

† 马克 *Mǎkè* Mark, a foreign student

‡ 王 *Wáng* Wang (the teacher's surname)

§ 王小明 *Wáng Xiǎomíng* Wang Xiaoming (an example name)

¶ 小明 *Xiǎomíng* Xiaoming (given name)

Mark still didn't understand. Why would his name be the same as the road outside? 3

What the Name Means

The next day, Mark went to the office and asked Teacher Wang, "Why does everyone laugh at my name?" Teacher Wang said, "Look at the road outside. Cars drive on it and people walk on it. In Chinese, a road like that is called a 'ma lu'." Mark went red. "So my name means 'road'! Everyone laughed because I'm called 'Road'!" "That's right," said Teacher Wang. "But they weren't laughing at you. They just thought the name was funny." 4

Then Teacher Wang told Mark how Chinese names are made. In a Chinese name, the family name comes first and the given name comes after it. Take "Wang Xiaoming": his family name is Wang, and he is called Xiaoming. The family name is usually one character; the given name is sometimes one character and sometimes two. 5

6 王[†]老师说：“爸爸妈妈给孩子起名字的时候，常常想很长时间。因为名字里的字都有意思，所以要选好的字。读音也很重要，名字要好听。”马克[‡]问：“老师，那我能换一个名字吗？”王老师笑着说：“可以啊。你可以和同学们一起想。”

新名字

7 下午，马克和同学们一起想新名字。大家都说，姓不用换，还是姓马[§]，因为“马”是一个很好的姓。一个同学说：“那你叫‘马上’吧！以后老师叫你，你就马上来！”大家又笑了。马克说：“不行，不行！我不想再叫一个有意思的名字了。”

8 他们一个字一个字地想，想了很长时间。最后，大家选了两个字：“明”和“远”。

† 王 *Wáng* Wang (the teacher's surname)
‡ 马克 *Mǎkè* Mark, a foreign student
§ 马 *Mǎ* Ma (a surname)

Teacher Wang said, "When parents name a child, they often think about it for a long time. Because every character in a name has a meaning, they have to choose good ones. The sound matters too: a name should sound nice." "Then, Teacher," asked Mark, "can I change my name?" Teacher Wang smiled. "Of course. You can think of one together with your classmates." 6

A New Name

In the afternoon, Mark and his classmates sat down to think of a new name. Everyone agreed that he didn't need to change his surname. He would stay Ma, because Ma is a fine surname. One classmate said, "Then call yourself 'Ma Shang'! Then when the teacher calls you, you'll come 'right away'!" Everyone laughed again. "No way!" said Mark. "I don't want another funny name." 7

They went through it character by character and thought for a long time. In the end they chose two characters: ming and yuan. 8

8 “明”有“亮”的意思，“远”是“很远的地方”的“远”。马克[†]想：我是从很远的地方来的，以后我也想去很多很远的地方。这两个字的读音也很好听。他高兴地说：“好！我叫马明远[‡]！”

9 第二天上课，马克又站起来：“大家好，我姓马[§]，叫马明远。这个名字是我和同学们一起想的。”这次，没有人笑。王[¶]老师说：“这个名字真好！”马克心里很高兴。他想：因为大家都帮我，所以我有了一个好名字。

10 可是下课以后，他的好朋友们还是叫他“马路”。原来，大家都记住了这个有意思的名字。马克也不生气，他笑着说：“没关系。马路也很好，马路很长，能到很远很远的地方。”

† 马克 *Mǎkè* Mark, a foreign student

‡ 马明远 *Mǎ Míngyuǎn* Ma Mingyuan, Mark's new name

§ 马 *Mǎ* Ma (a surname)

¶ 王 *Wáng* Wang (the teacher's surname)

Ming means "bright", and yuan is the yuan in "a faraway place". Mark thought: I came from far away, and one day I want to go to lots of faraway places. And the two characters sounded nice, too. He said happily, "Great! I'll be Ma Mingyuan!" 8

In class the next day, Mark stood up again. "Hello, everyone. My surname is Ma, and my name is Ma Mingyuan. My classmates and I thought of this name together." This time nobody laughed. Teacher Wang said, "What a good name!" Mark felt very happy inside. He thought: because everyone helped me, I've got a good name. 9

But after class, his good friends still called him "Ma Lu". It turned out that this funny name had stuck in everyone's mind. Mark didn't mind. He laughed and said, "That's all right. Ma Lu is good too. A road is long, and it can take you very, very far." 10